

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Technical Skills - I have over 8 years of experience producing audio/music using DAWs. In this time, I have experimented with a variety of DAWs including FL Studio, Ableton, Logic, Pro Tools, Audacity, and Reaper. This has allowed me to develop a high-level of understanding of their workings and the related processes involved in music/audio production, such as signal flow, recording, sound design, arrangement, mixing, mastering, etc. The breadth of DAWs I have used also means I'm not dependent on one piece of software and can adapt to different studio environments if needed. Live Industry Experience - I've worked as a live sound engineer and technician for 'Valleys Events' which gave me crucial FOH and live sound experience outside of university. On top of this, I have collaborated with friends to plan, produce, and run our own event – converting a barn/farm into a music venue from scratch, where I handled the planning, stage build, equipment setup, sound, and event coordination almost entirely alone, I also performed as a DJ for the first time to a crowd at this event. Teaching Experience - During my gap year I taught creative music technology and DJing courses at my old college, just a few weeks after I graduated. Teaching something forces a deeper level of understanding, and this experience improved both my technical knowledge and my ability to communicate complex processes clearly to others. Teaching is also well known to be the best way to learn and consolidate knowledge. Communication & People Management - Working in retail as a customer service assistant and Team Leader/Shift Manager has also allowed me to build confidence talking to people from all walks of life, formally and informally. Being a manager in a fast-paced environment has also given me plenty of transferable skills that will be useful when managing my own business/employees. Some skills include delegation, conflict resolution, and keeping things running smoothly under pressure. Collaboration - All of my prior experience means that I'm accustomed to working and collaborating with others; a key skill which is crucial in the music/audio industry, and something which will play a crucial part in my role running HAZMAT.	No Experience Running A Business - This is the first time I've attempted to build and run a company. I have no formal legal knowledge and, while I understand basic business concepts at a baseline level, the reality of operating a company and doing things like writing contracts, filing tax, and maintaining legal compliances/requirements is new territory for me. Skills Gaps Outside My Core Expertise - Graphic design, social media strategy, marketing, and legal drafting are not strengths. In the short term these are roles I'll need to cover myself before I can delegate them, which takes up valuable time and means I could produce results that are ineffective and insufficient - I'll need to gain a basic understanding of the relevant skills to be able to get my business off the ground successfully. Time Management - time management is something that I've always struggled with personally. I always show up and I always put the work in, but I'm always a few minutes late to almost everything. In a professional setting - especially managing a team, client relationships, etc... - this is something I need to work on. Large Number of Commitments - Balancing university, part-time work, and building a business means my time and energy are always split. This limits how fast I can grow each area of my life and how much I can take on at once during the early stages of the business. More importantly, the sheer amount of commitments I will have creates a big risk of burning out - poor mental health is common in the creative industries, particularly for emerging artists and entrepreneurs who normalise overworking as part of the process. For me, I've encountered this with music production multiple times in the last 8 years, and sometimes it's resulted in me losing interest in making music, essentially meaning I would've got more done if I didn't overwork myself in a short period of time (doing so had the opposite effect I was intending), so in future recognising the early signs of burnout and taking time for recovery is a necessity. Without it, the quality of my creative output drops, my decision-making suffers, and the business could lose its most important asset.

Financial Competence – Maybe my biggest strength of all is my financial competence and stability. From a young age I was taught about how to manage my money effectively, cut costs at every corner, and save. I also more recently educated myself on how to trade and invest so that I could boost the value of my savings. These are key skills for managing a business and will help ensure financial sustainability. From these skills I have a very developed understanding of risk vs reward, risk tolerance, emotional tolerance/balance, purchasing power/value, and more.	
OPPORTUNITIES University – being at university means I already have a great network for support, development, and collaboration, with many learning opportunities and recourses available. I'm surrounded by people studying music, business, design, and tech who are all looking for the same thing I am - real experience and opportunities. I'm already building HAZMAT's early team from this network, and the longer I'm here the more connections I can hopefully make before I graduate and that window closes. Unique Ideas - Unique ideas are what make an artist stand out. I'm known for pop-up raves in my hometown, most notably out the boot of my car where I set up DJ decks in the boot and use the car's beefed-up sound system as a PA rig, the unique nature of performing a set from the boot of my car attracted many new fans. These events weren't planned as a marketing stunt; they just happened because I wanted to practice DJing and didn't have a venue to play at. But eventually my friends wanted to come along, they then spread the word and people I didn't even know started to show up, then they talked about it, and it built something big out of nothing. By accident or not, my mindset and drive to do things like this, without a budget, has created many accidental opportunities and it's something I know I have and should continue to utilise going forward. More accessible technology and equipment – Prices of technology and equipment is generally becoming more affordable which presents a great opportunity to accumulate assets and lower startup costs. This means I can spend less money on hiring studios and equipment rentals as I grow.	THREATS Market Saturation – With audio technology improving and becoming more accessible/cheaper every day, the gap between a bedroom producer and a professional-sounding release has almost disappeared and an increasingly vast number of people are competing for the same market spaces that I am targeting. Getting noticed is harder than it's ever been, and I'm going to have to work harder to stand out than someone doing this ten years ago would have. This situation is only going to get worse as well, with AI producers beginning to take a share too. Trends & Consumer Behaviour Constantly Changing – In a time where everyone is addicted to quick dopamine hits and short form content rules the internet, consumer interests and trends don't stay the same for long and are hard to predict. Targeting niches, trends, and hype is high risk. Building something that lasts in this environment will be very difficult, but I'm aware that my timing and adaptability are going to matter as much as quality here. Rapid Development of AI/Technology - Technological developments require you to develop with them, which will cost valuable time to learn and financial investment to keep up to date with the latest tech, equipment, etc. AI tools are already changing how music gets made, mixed, and even marketed, and while I enjoy learning these new tools, keeping up requires time and money that I don't always have, and falling behind here could have real consequences for how competitive my production output is.

Growing Freelance/Independent Market – I don't need a big label or agency to get started like I would have decades ago because I can release music, promote shows, and build an audience using all the independent services available to musicians now. This suits the way I already work because I've always figured things out myself rather than waiting for help and also means I can keep full control over my own work and profits as well as the business'.

Macro-Economic Stress – Local, national, and international economic stability is extremely volatile and under immense stress. Despite creative industries being highly lucrative, they are usually the first to take a hit when major economic crisis hit as they are not deemed to be 'essential'. With many grassroots venues, agents, studios, etc, struggling in the current economy, more are shutting down as time goes on, this creates even more market saturation for an increasing number of aspiring creatives, performers and engineers as they will be competing for a decreasing number of opportunities/work. That's the reality I'm stepping into, and I need to plan around it rather than assuming it will improve.